

Portable paints and chemical colours

Artists have painted outdoors for centuries, but it was not until the mid-19th century that finished paintings were produced outside. Inventions made this easier: originally, artists had made their own paint by grinding and mixing pigments with egg or oil, but from the end of the 18th century, the first ready-made paint was sold in pigs' bladders. Paint was squeezed through a tiny hole in the bladder, which was then sealed with a tack, but it was messy. In 1841, the first collapsible metal tubes of ready-mixed paint were produced. Portable paints enabled artists to paint *en plein air* ('in the open air'), and folding easels and portable paint boxes also became available. Soon manufacturers sold pre-stretched canvases already primed with white gesso.

Additionally, new artificial pigments were created. New colours and improved versions of established ones began appearing. Cobalt blue was first sold in 1807, cadmium yellow in 1820 and viridian in 1838. These were followed by cheap synthetic versions of other colours, such as French ultramarine, zinc white and cobalt violet.



Pissarro, *The Artist's Palette with a Landscape*, c.1878